

[Lesson 28](#): “O God, Where Art Thou?” (See L28 [Class Member Study Guide](#))

Purpose: To help us better endure adversity by turning to the Savior.

†1. “The beds were too hard.” *Write of an adversity in your life.*

1. Joseph Smith’s prayer in Liberty Jail, and the Lord’s response

“Church Headquarters at Far West; The Battle of Crooked River; and Haun’s Mill Massacre,”

(See *Our Heritage*, [45-49](#); and Map 2 *Class Member Study Guide*, 30.)

†2. Missouri Time Line

†3. Clay County and Liberty Jail

†4. President Joseph Fielding Smith

• D&C 121:1-6; D&C 121:7-33; D&C 122; D&C 121:7-10. †5. Elder B. H. Roberts

How have the revelations given in the Liberty Jail blessed your life?

2. The Savior’s perfect understanding of our sufferings and adversity

• D&C 122:5-8. (Think of your own trials as you read these verses.) †6. Elder Neal A. Maxwell

How can remembering the Savior’s suffering help us be faithful in our own tribulations?

How can we partake more fully of his comfort and strength through the atonement?

3. Purposes of adversity

• D&C 98:12, 14-15; 101:4; 136:31; 101:1-2, 122:7.

How can understanding these purposes of adversity help us to “endure it well”? (See 121:8.)

Why is adversity not withheld from the righteous?

Some sources of adversity: 1) transgression, 2) there is “opposition in all things,” even for the righteous, 3) natural consequence of the frailty and corruptibility of the mortal body, 4) accidents, 5) result of our own choices that aren’t necessarily transgressions, 6) results of others’ choices—things that God can protect us from but sometimes does not because ‘the basic gospel law is free agency and eternal development’ (Spencer W. Kimball, *Faith Precedes the Miracle* [1973], 96). 7) “to accomplish the Lord’s own purposes in our life that we may receive the refinement that comes from testing,” (Elder Richard G. Scott, “[Trust in the Lord](#),” *Ensign*, Nov 1995, 16) (See *Lesson Manual*)

†7. Elder Harold B. Lee †8. Elder Orson Pratt †9. Elder Orson F. Whitney †10. President Marion G. Romney

• 2 Nephi 2:11; Alma 32:5-6; 62:41; Helaman 12:1-3. There “is an opposition in all things,” “their afflictions had truly humbled them;” and “the unsteadiness of the hearts of the children of men”.

4. The Lord’s counsel to those who experience adversity

• D&C 24:8; 31:9; 54:10; 121:7. (Be patient in afflictions. See also Alma 17:11.)

How can we increase our patience to endure trials?

How can we come to see adversity from the Lord’s eternal perspective?

• D&C 98:1. Rejoice and give thanks.

• D&C 98:11. Remain obedient and “cleave to all good.”

• D&C 101:36-38. Care for the soul, not for the body, and seek the Lord.

• D&C 122:9. We should not fear what man may do, for God will be with us forever (See also D&C 98:13.)

Why are some embittered by trials while others grow and are strengthened?

How can we help others through their trials?

What blessings can come from helping others during our own trials? (See Luke 9:24 and Gal. 6:2.)

How can we prepare now to be strong later when we may experience greater adversity?

5. The Lord’s promises to those who are faithful in adversity

• D&C 3:8; 24:8; 112:13; 122:4—The Lord will be with us, stand by us, and heal us in our afflictions.

What experiences have shown you that the Lord is with you during times of trial

• D&C 58:2-4; 101:35-36; 103:12; 121:29; 127:4; 136:31. Those who are faithful in tribulation will receive glory and joy.

• D&C 98:3; 122:7. All things will work together for our good. (See also D&C 90:24; 100:15; 2 Ne. 2:2.)

Remembering the adversity you wrote down, what have you learned and how have you grown from it?

†11. Elder James E. Faust

†12. The Prophet Joseph Smith

†13. *Doctrine and Covenants Manual* selections

What can we do in our trials to feel the peace the Lord speaks of in D&C 121:7?

Next Week: [Lesson 29](#): “Building the Kingdom of God in Nauvoo, Illinois;” See L29 [Study Guide](#).

(You can download a free LDS Institute manual at: [Doctrine and Covenants Manual: Religion 324 and 325](#).) † •

†1. **“The beds were too hard.”:** “Brother Jack Nelson, our high priest group instructor, told us about one of his good friends, who is a businessman and an elders quorum president. He is a good man, but had sheltered his sons from responsibility. One of his sons, who was called to serve a mission to Japan, left the MTC here in Provo by taxi and arrived at Jack’s home recently (about a week before) saying, ‘I just couldn’t do it. The beds were too hard.’” (Provo Central Stake, Rivergrove 3rd Ward, Priesthood meeting, May 2, 1982, [Personal File I-169])

†2. **Missouri Time Line:**

Jan 1831: The first missionaries arrive in Missouri.

Jul 1831: The Lord designated Missouri as the location for the city of Zion.

Aug 1831: Joseph Smith dedicated the temple site in Independence.

Jul 1833: A mob attacked the Saints in Independence, Missouri.

Nov 1833: The Battle of the Big Blue occurred. The Saints were driven from Jackson County to Clay County, Missouri.

May-Jun 1834: Zion’s Camp marched from Kirtland, Ohio, to Clay County, Missouri.

Jun 1836: Citizens of Clay County asked the Saints to leave the county.

Sep 1836: The Saints began moving to Far West, Missouri, after fleeing from the mobs in Kirtland, Ohio.

Oct 1838: The Battle of Crooked River occurred. Governor Boggs of Missouri issued his extermination order.

Oct 1838-Apr 1839: Joseph Smith and other Church leaders were kept as prisoners in Missouri.

Apr 1839: The Saints fled from Missouri to Illinois. (See *Lesson Manual* L27 Additional Teaching Ideas.)

†3. **Clay County and Liberty Jail:** “After the Saints were driven from Jackson County in late 1833, they found refuge in nearby Clay County until they were asked to leave in 1836. From Clay County, they moved about 60 miles north and established the community of Far West and other smaller settlements.

“... However, there continued to be conflicts among some of the Saints. Several leaders were excommunicated, including Oliver Cowdery and David Whitmer.

“In addition, ... there continued to be conflicts with other residents in northern Missouri. In 1838, mobs and militia members began more attacks. On 25 October, three Church members were killed during a battle at Crooked River, including David W. Patten, an Apostle. Two days later, Governor Liburn W. Boggs of Missouri issued an order that “the Mormons must be

treated as enemies and *must be exterminated* or driven from the state.” (*History of the Church*, 3:175)

“On October, a mob of approximately 200 men killed 17 men and boys at Haun’s Mill. The next day, Joseph Smith and approximately 50 other Church leaders were arrested on false charges. Most of these leaders were released within three weeks. However, six of them, including Joseph and Hyrum Smith, were detained despite their innocence. In November they were marched first to Independence, then to Richmond, and then to Liberty, where they were incarcerated in Liberty Jail until April 1839.

“Conditions in Liberty Jail were harsh. The prisoners were kept in the lower level, which was like a dungeon—dark, cold, and unsanitary. The food was inadequate and filthy. The Prophet and his companions had only a little straw on the stone floor for their beds, with meager blankets for cover. The ceiling was so low that some of the brethren including Joseph and Hyrum, could not stand upright. They were also under constant threat of death.

“While the Prophet was imprisoned, about 8,000 Saints in Missouri were forced out of their homes as a result of the governor’s extermination order. Many of them were robbed, beaten, and killed by the mobs as they fled to the state of Illinois. The Prophet heard reports of the Saints’ suffering and pleaded with the Lord for help. In response, the Lord gave some powerful revelations. The Prophet included them in a letter to Church leaders in Quincy, Illinois, who were directing the Saints’ exodus from Missouri. Portions of these revelations are now sections 121, 122, and 123 of the Doctrine and Covenants.” (*Lesson Manual*.)

Recommended Reading:

1. Elder David A. Bednar, “[The Tender Mercies of the Lord](#),” *Ensign*, May 2005.

2. Elder James E. Faust, “[The Refiner’s Fire](#),” *Ensign*, May 1979, 53.

3. William C. Beardall, “[O God, Where Art Thou](#),” presents a very fine recap of the problems in Caldwell County, Missouri.

4. Orson F. Whitney, *The Life of Heber C. Kimball*, [Chapter 29](#).

5. Nancy R. Jensen, Doctrine and Covenants Lesson #28 “[O God, Where Art Thou?](#)”

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†4. **President Joseph Fielding Smith:** “After the mock trial in Richmond, Joseph Smith and his five companions were imprisoned in Liberty, Clay County, for a period of six months. Here they suffered, during that time, many untold hardships. Much of the time they were bound in chains. Their food was often not fit to eat, and never wholesome or prepared with the thought of proper nourishment. Several times poison was administered to them in their food, which made them sick nigh unto death, and only the promised blessings of the Lord saved them. Their bed was on the floor, or on the flat side of a hewn white oak log, and in this manner they were forced to suffer.” (*Essentials in Church History*, 210)

†5. **Elder B. H. Roberts, referring to Sections 121 and 122:** “Such outgivings as these made Liberty jail, for a time, a center of instruction. The eyes of the saints were turned to it as the place whence would come encouragement, counsel—the word of the Lord. It was more temple than prison, so long as the Prophet was there. It was a place of meditation and prayer. A temple, first of all, is a place of prayer, and prayer is communion with God. It is the ‘infinite in man seeking the infinite in God.’ Where they find each other, there is holy sanctuary—a temple. Joseph Smith sought God in this rude prison, and found him. Out of the midst of his tribulations he called upon God in passionate earnestness.” (*Comprehensive History of the Church*, 526)

†6. **Elder Neal A. Maxwell:** “As part of His infinite atonement, Jesus ... has borne the sins, griefs, sorrows, and, declared Jacob, the pains of every man, woman, and child (see 2 Nephi 9:21). Having been perfected in His empathy, Jesus thus knows how to succor us... Nothing is beyond His redeeming reach or His encircling empathy. Therefore, we should not complain about our own life’s not being a rose garden when we remember who wore the crown of thorns!” (“[Overcome ... Even As I Also Overcame](#),” *Ensign*, May 1987, 72)

†7. **Elder Harold B. Lee said:** “living the gospel of Jesus Christ is no guarantee that adversity will not come into our lives; but living the gospel does give us the strength and faith and power to rise above that adversity and look beyond the present trouble to the brighter day” (quoted by A. Theodore Tuttle, in Conference Report, [Oct. 1967, 15](#); or Improvement Era, Dec. 1967, 47).

†8. **Elder Orson Pratt:** “It is for our development, our purification, our growth, our education and advancement, that we buffet the fierce waves of sorrow and misfortune; and we shall be all the stronger and better when we have swum the flood and stand upon the farther shore.” (*Latter-day Prophets*, 4:228)

†9. **Elder Orson F. Whitney:** “From time to time the Lord will bring trials and vicissitudes upon His people to sift and purify them as wheat. The chaff will eventually all be blown away and nothing but the wheat remain. In every change that has come, God has had in view the development, growth and purification of his people.” (*Collected Discourses, Volume 1*)

†10. **President Marion G. Romney:** “I have seen the remorse and despair in the lives of men who, in the hour of trial, have cursed God and died spiritually. And I have seen people rise to great heights from what seemed to be unbearable burdens.

“Finally, I have sought the Lord in my own extremities and learned for myself that my soul has made its greatest growth as I have been driven to my knees by adversity and affliction.” (*Conference Report, Oct. 1969, 60.*)

†11. **Elder James E. Faust:** “In the pain, the agony, and the heroic endeavors of life, we pass through a refiner’s fire, and the insignificant and the unimportant in our lives can melt away like dross and make our faith bright, intact, and strong.... It is part of the purging toll exacted of some to become acquainted with God. In the agonies of life, we seem to listen better to the faint, godly whisperings of the Divine Shepherd.” (“[The Refiner’s Fire](#),” *Ensign*, May 1979, 53)

†12. **The Prophet Joseph Smith:** “I am like a huge, rough stone rolling down from a high mountain; and the only polishing I get is when some corner gets rubbed off by coming in contact with something else, striking with accelerated force against religious bigotry, priestcraft, lawyer-craft, doctor-craft, lying editors, suborned judges and jurors, and the authority of perjured executives, backed by mobs, blasphemers, licentious and corrupt men and women—all hell knocking off a corner here and a corner there. Thus I will become a smooth and polished shaft in the quiver of the Almighty.” (*History of the Church*, 5:401)

†13. *Doctrine and Covenants Manual: Religion 324 and 325*

D&C 121:11-25. What Happens When a Member Falls from Activity into Apostasy?

Elder George Q. Cannon: “The Saints should not imagine that because they know the truth and the Work of God at the present time, that they will always know these things and therefore be able to stand. If they lose the Holy Spirit through their transgressions, from that moment their knowledge respecting the Work of God ceases to increase and becomes dead; a short time only elapses before such persons deny the faith. They may not deny that the Work was ever true, or that the Elders were ever the servants of God, but they will place a limit and say, ‘Up to such a time the work was true and the Elders were all right, but, after that, they went astray,’—that very period being the time at which they themselves had committed some act or acts to forfeit the Spirit of God and kill the growth of that knowledge which they had had bestowed upon them. This has been the case in numerous instances in the past. . . . It is plain that it is they who have transgressed, and thereby driven the Spirit of the Lord from them; and at the very time they say the Church of God strayed, they themselves were guilty of transgression.” (“Knowledge, without the Aid of the Spirit of the Lord, Not Sufficient to Save,” *Millennial Star*, 8 Aug. 1863, pp. 505-6.) (In *Doctrine and Covenants Manual: Religion 324 and 325*, 297.)

D&C 121:15-16. Do Enemies of the Church Prosper?

Elder Heber J. Grant: “Our enemies have never done anything that has injured this work of God, and they never will. I look around, I read, I reflect, and I ask the question, Where are the men of influence, of power and prestige, who have worked against the Latter-day Saints? Where is the reputation, for honor and courage, of the governors of Missouri and Illinois, the judges, and all others who have come here to Utah on special missions against the Latter-day Saints? Where are there people to do them honor? They cannot be found. . . . Where are the men who have assailed this work? Where is their influence? They have faded away like dew before the sun. We need have no fears, we Latter-day Saints. God will continue to sustain this work; He will sustain the right. If we are loyal, if we are true, if we are worthy of this Gospel, of which God has given us a testimony, there is no danger that the world can ever injure us. We can never be injured . . . by any mortals, except ourselves.” (In Conference Report, Apr. 1909, p. 110.) (In *Doctrine and Covenants Manual: Religion 324 and 325*, 297.)

D&C 121:21. Does God Punish Later Generations for the Sins of Their Parents?

President Joseph F. Smith: The “infidel will impart infidelity to his children if he can. The whoremonger will not raise a pure, righteous posterity. He will impart seeds of disease and misery, if not of death and destruction, upon his offspring, which will continue upon his children and descend to his children’s children to the third and fourth generation. It is perfectly natural that the children should inherit from their fathers, and if they sow the seeds of corruption, crime and loathsome disease, their children will reap the fruits thereof. Not in accordance with God’s wishes for His wish is that men will not sin and therefore will not transmit the consequences of their sin to their children, but that they will keep His commandments, and be free from sin and from entailing the effects of sin upon their offspring; but inasmuch as men will not hearken unto the Lord, but will become a law unto themselves, and will commit sin they will justly reap the consequences of their own iniquity, and will naturally impart its fruits to their children to the third and fourth generation.” (In Conference Report, Oct. 1912, p. 9; see also D&C 124:50.) (In *Doctrine and Covenants Manual: Religion 324 and 325*, 297.)

D&C 121:26. In What Context Was the prophet Speaking When He promised the “Unspeakable Gift of the Holy Ghost”?

This section and the two following are excerpts from letters written by the Prophet Joseph Smith from Liberty Jail. The Prophet’s comments that preceded this passage were not included in the Doctrine and Covenants but are of interest in setting the stage for his comments on the gifts of the Holy Ghost:

“The things of God are of deep import; and time, and experience, and careful and ponderous and solemn thoughts can only find them out. Thy mind, O man! If thou wilt lead a soul unto salvation, must stretch as high as the utmost heavens, and search into and contemplate the darkest abyss, and the broad expanse of eternity—thou must commune with God. How much more dignified and noble are the thoughts of God, than the vain imaginations of the human heart! None but fools will trifle with the souls of men.” (*History of the Church*, 3:295-96.) (In *Doctrine and Covenants Manual: Religion 324 and 325*, 297.)

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